Femme Fatale

Men drive the events of **Shaheen Akhtar's** novel, but the women who orbit them are its true heroes



BELOVED RONGOMALA
by Shaheen Akhtar; translated by Shabnam Nadiya
EKA (WESTLAND)
₹499; 294 pages

Who could resist a saga that begins with a drunken zamindar king, a fearsome and loyal henchman, and the severed head of a beautiful courtesan? With a startling opening scene, full of high drama, *Beloved Rongomala* (originally *Shokhi Rongomala*), written by award-winning Bangladeshi author Shaheen Akhtar and translated by writer Shabnam Nadiya, draws readers into a gripping and heart-rending tale that explores the gender, class and caste struggles of 18th-century Bengal.

Set in the years of the British East India Company's burgeoning influence, the historical novel revolves around the household of Raj Chandra Chowdhury, a self-absorbed feudal lord of minor import, who spends his days in the pursuit of gratification and pleasure. Wrapped as he is in a bubble of entitlement and self-supremacy, the zamindar cares, or sees, little of the impending threats to his kingdom, both from foreign might and family coups.

While Chowdhury occupies the seat of authority, political and domestic, it is the women who orbit him that Akhtar brings forward as primary voices. The central ones are those of Phuleshwari, the once child-bride whose family fortunes and social station made her an ideal match, but who now lives in the shadow of another, and of the titular Rongomala, Chowdhury's low-born mistress, with whom he is singularly obsessed.

Whereas the infantile Phuleshwari remains in arrested development, Rongomala is a charismatic nautch girl of peerless beauty and confidence, who attains dizzying heights of privilege as the king's favoured one. Her mistake was in reaching for some semblance of a legacy, in the form of a lake dug in her name—an unthinkable act of hubris for a member of her caste.

Based on *Chowdhury's Lorai* (Chowdhury's Battle), a local legend now shared through the indigenous music tradition called *pala gaan* and reimagined by Akhtar with the women at its heart instead of the zamindar, the plot takes off with the decapitation of Rongomala, launching the reader into this complex web of family politics, conspiracy, desire, and treachery.

Underlying it all is the quest for power—that of weak men wanting to keep and assert dominance over entrapped women seeking a better hand. Each of their histories echoes the unsurprising, oft-told struggle of women vying for legitimacy in a man's world, using whatever currency they are able to harness—beauty or piety, gossip or wile.

Much as she did in *Talaash*, her second novel, about rape survivors of the Bangladesh Liberation War in 1971—for which she won the 3rd Asian Literary Award—Akhtar succeeds in bringing to light the untold stories of those left silenced by patriarchy, not as casualties of gender wars but as heroines of their own epics.

The expansive narratives partner with evocative imagery of the rural East, the lilting style of fireside folk tales, and deep cultural nuances expertly rendered in Nadiya's translation to create a compelling book that delivers a well-known story in a refreshing way. ■

Ishani Nandi



AKHTAR'S BOOK BRINGS TO LIGHT THE STORIES OF THOSE SILENCED BY PATRIARCHY